



GLOBAL SECURITY ASSESSMENT

Q1 2026

Worldwide Threat Overview & Regional Security Posture Guidance

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This assessment provides unclassified open-source intelligence synthesis, regional threat analysis, and security posture guidance for corporate travelers, executives, and organizations with global operations. Prepared by Aegis Readiness Group LLC.

Readiness, Where It Matters.

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01 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Q1 2026 Global Security Assessment is issued under conditions of extraordinary geopolitical volatility. The defining event of this quarter — and arguably the most significant security development since the 2022 invasion of Ukraine — is the joint US-Israeli military campaign against Iran, which commenced on 28 February 2026. The conflict has produced a CRITICAL threat rating for the CENTCOM AOR, with Iranian counter-strikes targeting US military bases across the Gulf, Hezbollah re-engagement against Israel, and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz threatening catastrophic disruption to global energy and supply chains. All commercial operations in the Persian Gulf region require immediate review.

In the Americas, the February 22 elimination of CJNG leader "El Mencho" by Mexican Special Forces triggered nationwide cartel retaliation, airport shutdowns, and widespread road blockages. While the situation has since stabilized in major urban centers, the succession crisis within CJNG creates an elevated and fluid threat environment for corporate travelers in Mexico. Separately, Latin American cartels are accelerating adoption of AI-enabled deepfakes and drone capabilities, raising the operational complexity of the threat to business operations throughout the region.

In Europe, Russia-Ukraine peace negotiations remain unresolved despite the January 2026 "Coalition of the Willing" Paris Declaration. Active fighting continues in eastern Ukraine, with Russian drone strikes reaching Kharkiv, Dnipro, and Sloviansk in March. A fragile ceasefire framework is being negotiated but Russia has rejected NATO troop deployments on Ukrainian soil, and peace remains uncertain. European business operations face continued hybrid warfare threats including cyberattacks on critical infrastructure attributed to Russian state actors.

The World Economic Forum's Global Risks Report 2026 identifies geoeconomic confrontation as the top near-term risk globally, with 50% of surveyed experts anticipating a turbulent or stormy world over the next two years. Organizations with

international operations must treat security planning as a core operational function — not a compliance exercise.

02 GLOBAL THREAT OVERVIEW MATRIX

AOR	REGION	THREAT LEVEL	KEY DRIVER	TREND
AMERICAS	CONUS / LATAM	ELEVATED	Post-EI Mencho CJNG fragmentation, World Cup risk	↑ Rising
EUROPE	Western & Eastern EU	ELEVATED	Ukraine war — fragile ceasefire negotiations	→ Stable
MIDDLE EAST	CENTCOM	CRITICAL	Active US-Israel strikes on Iran; Strait of Hormuz	↑ Surge
AFRICA	Sub-Saharan / North	HIGH	Sahel jihadist expansion, DRC M23 advance	→ Stable
ASIA PACIFIC	INDOPACOM	ELEVATED	China-Taiwan gray zone, S. China Sea incidents	↑ Rising
ARCTIC/OTHER	Emerging Environments	MONITORED	Great power competition, Arctic militarization	↑ Rising

Threat levels are assessed using open-source intelligence synthesis, incident reporting, and pattern analysis as of March 2026. CRITICAL = active large-scale military conflict with direct threat to all personnel in AOR. HIGH = active armed conflict or terror activity posing direct threat. ELEVATED = significant ongoing risk requiring enhanced precautions. MODERATE = manageable risk with standard professional protocols. MONITORED = emerging indicators warrant attention.

REGIONAL ASSESSMENTS

03 AMERICAS

THREAT LEVEL: **ELEVATED**

SITUATIONAL OVERVIEW

The Americas AOR has seen its most significant security disruption in years following the February 22 elimination of CJNG leader Nemesio "El Mencho" Oseguera by Mexican Special Forces with US intelligence support. The operation triggered coordinated nationwide retaliation: road blockages across 20 states, attacks at Guadalajara International Airport, vehicle burnings, and US State Department shelter-in-place orders for Jalisco, Tamaulipas, Michoacan, Guerrero, and Nuevo Leon. As of late February the immediate wave of violence has stabilized, but CJNG fragmentation and succession battles represent a sustained elevated threat. AI-enabled deepfake voice scams and drone use by cartels are emerging threats for corporate travelers. The 2026 FIFA World Cup, hosted partly in Mexico, introduces additional security complexity in host cities. CONUS faces elevated domestic extremism indicators ahead of midterm election cycles.

KEY THREAT DRIVERS

- Post-El Mencho CJNG succession crisis — fragmentation producing more violent factional conflict
- Cartel adoption of AI deepfakes, drone delivery systems, and coordinated disinformation campaigns
- US-Mexico tension over sovereignty following US intelligence role in El Mencho operation
- 2026 FIFA World Cup security demands straining Mexican federal security resources
- Domestic extremism and election-cycle unrest indicators rising in CONUS
- US "Donroe Doctrine" creating unpredictable bilateral posture toward LATAM states

RECOMMENDED POSTURE

- Avoid travel to Jalisco, Tamaulipas, Michoacan, Guerrero, Sinaloa, and Zacatecas (Level 3-4)
- Monitor State Department advisories daily — post-El Mencho environment remains fluid
- All Mexico travel requires vetted ground transport; avoid overnight highway travel
- Verify voice communications via secondary channel — AI deepfake scams targeting executives
- World Cup host city travel (Guadalajara, Mexico City) requires enhanced security protocols
- Request specific Mexico AOR assessment from Aegis before any in-country deployment

NOTABLE INCIDENTS / INDICATORS (Q1 2026)

DATE	LOCATION	INCIDENT	SIGNIFICANCE
Feb 22	Tapalpa, Jalisco	Mexican SF kills CJNG leader El Mencho; nationwide retaliation	CRITICAL — shelter-in-place issued
Feb 22	Guadalajara Airport	CJNG members enter terminal; mass evacuation of passengers	HIGH — airport shutdowns across Mexico
Feb 23	Puerto Vallarta	Road blockages; commercial flights suspended for 24+ hours	HIGH — travel disruption throughout Jalisco
Mar 7	Caribbean/E. Pacific	US military strikes on alleged CJNG drug-trafficking vessels	ELEV — US unilateral action posture active

04 EUROPE

THREAT LEVEL: **ELEVATED**

SITUATIONAL OVERVIEW

Europe's threat environment in Q1 2026 is defined by the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict and the unresolved question of a negotiated settlement. The January 6 "Coalition of the Willing" Paris summit produced a declaration on security guarantees for Ukraine, with France and the UK pledging military hubs on Ukrainian territory post-ceasefire, and the US committing to lead a ceasefire monitoring mechanism. However, Russia has rejected foreign troop deployments on Ukrainian soil and continues to make territorial gains in the Donbas. Active drone and missile exchanges continue — Russia struck Kharkiv, Dnipro, and Sloviansk in March 2026, and Ukrainian forces struck Bryansk. A ceasefire remains possible but fragile; organizations should not plan on operational stability in Eastern Europe through 2026. Western Europe faces elevated hybrid warfare threats and political instability, with France, Germany, and the UK all navigating weak governments under pressure from populist movements.

KEY THREAT DRIVERS

- Russia-Ukraine war continues with front-line exchanges; ceasefire negotiations unresolved
- Russian hybrid warfare — cyber, disinformation, and sabotage targeting NATO infrastructure
- France, Germany, UK governments weakened by populist pressure; policy paralysis risk
- US "Donroe Doctrine" creating transatlantic tension and uncertainty over NATO commitments
- Russia-NATO proxy confrontation shifting from frontline trenches to hybrid warfare domain
- Belarus remains high-risk for Western nationals; arbitrary detention threat unchanged

RECOMMENDED POSTURE

- No travel to Russia or Belarus; suspend all operations — arbitrary detention risk is extreme
- Ukraine travel is mission-critical only; establish in-country emergency extraction plan
- Eastern European operations require daily intelligence monitoring and flexible schedules
- Implement robust cyber hygiene protocols — Russian APT activity against corporate networks elevated
- Register with embassy upon arrival in Poland, Baltic states, Romania, and Moldova
- Brief all staff on disinformation risks; verify news and communications independently

NOTABLE INCIDENTS / INDICATORS (Q1 2026)

DATE	LOCATION	INCIDENT	SIGNIFICANCE
Jan 6	Paris, France	Coalition of the Willing summit — Paris Declaration signed	MON — peace framework, no ceasefire yet
Jan 23	Abu Dhabi, UAE	US-Russia-Ukraine trilateral ceasefire framework talks begin	MON — negotiations ongoing
Mar 9	Kharkiv, Ukraine	Russian drone strike on residential neighborhood — 4 killed	HIGH — conflict continues
Mar 9	Bryansk, Russia	Ukrainian missile strike on city center — 6 civilian deaths	ELEV — escalatory exchange

05 MIDDLE EAST

THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

SITUATIONAL OVERVIEW

The CENTCOM AOR is at CRITICAL threat level following the joint US-Israeli military campaign against Iran that commenced February 28, 2026. The strikes — the largest US military operation in the Middle East since the 2003 Iraq invasion — targeted Iranian nuclear facilities, ballistic missile programs, naval assets, and leadership. Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was killed in opening strikes. Iran has counter-struck US military bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, UAE, and Turkey, and declared the Strait of Hormuz closed to commercial shipping. Hezbollah has re-engaged against northern Israel. The UN Security Council adopted Resolution 2817 condemning Iran's attacks on Gulf states. Between 600,000 and 1 million Iranian households are internally displaced. Global energy markets are severely disrupted; the IMF warns that every 10% increase in energy prices adds 0.5% to global inflation. ALL non-essential travel to the entire CENTCOM AOR must be suspended immediately.

KEY THREAT DRIVERS

- Active US-Israel military strikes against Iran targeting nuclear, missile, and leadership sites
- Iranian counter-strikes on US bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, UAE, Jordan, Turkey
- Strait of Hormuz closure — near-total halt of tanker traffic disrupting 20% of global oil
- Hezbollah missile and drone attacks on northern Israel and Tel Aviv following Iran strikes
- Iran cyber offensive — 150+ hacktivist incidents, attacks on Gulf financial and energy systems
- Global supply chain and energy price disruption creating cascading economic security risks

RECOMMENDED POSTURE

- IMMEDIATE EVACUATION recommended for all non-essential personnel in CENTCOM AOR
- Contact Aegis immediately for emergency extraction planning — do not wait for clarity
- All maritime operations in Red Sea and Persian Gulf are suspended pending Hormuz reopening
- Gulf state operations (KSA, UAE, Qatar) are active conflict zones — shelter-in-place protocols
- Implement emergency cyber hardening — Iran-attributed APT and hacktivist activity is surging
- Energy sector and financial operations globally face elevated cyber threat from Iranian proxies

NOTABLE INCIDENTS / INDICATORS (Q1 2026)

DATE	LOCATION	INCIDENT	SIGNIFICANCE
Feb 28	Tehran, Iran	Joint US-Israel strikes begin; Khamenei killed; emergency declared	CRITICAL — war commenced
Mar 1	Strait of Hormuz	Iran IRGC declares Hormuz closed; tanker traffic halted	CRITICAL — global energy disruption
Mar 2	Gulf states (multi)	Iranian ballistic missile/drone strikes on US bases in 7 countries	CRITICAL — active multi-nation strikes
Mar 4	Tel Aviv, Israel	Hezbollah fires rockets and drones on Tel Aviv — Israeli nationwide emergency	CRITICAL — regional war expanding

06 AFRICA

THREAT LEVEL: HIGH

SITUATIONAL OVERVIEW

Sub-Saharan Africa maintains a HIGH threat rating with the Sahel jihadist insurgency continuing to expand territory, and DRC experiencing significant territorial advances by M23 rebel forces backed by Rwanda. The Sahel region — Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger — remains under military governance following coups, with jihadist groups JNIM and ISIS-Sahel operating with increasing freedom after the expulsion of Western security partners. East Africa continues to see al-Shabaab cross-border attacks into Kenya and ongoing instability in Somalia. North Africa presents a mixed picture — Morocco and Tunisia offer manageable environments, while Libya remains fragmented and dangerous. The Iran war is generating secondary effects: energy price spikes are straining African economies dependent on fuel imports, increasing civil unrest indicators across the continent.

KEY THREAT DRIVERS

- JNIM and ISIS-Sahel expanding territorial control in Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger
- M23 rebel advance in eastern DRC displacing over 1 million civilians; Goma under threat
- Al-Shabaab cross-border attacks in Kenya and sustained rural control in Somalia
- Energy price spikes from Iran-Hormuz crisis straining fuel-dependent African economies
- Four military coups since 2020 creating fragile governance across Francophone West Africa
- Libya's fractured security environment — multiple armed factions control territory

RECOMMENDED POSTURE

- Suspend all travel to Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger, Somalia, Libya, and eastern DRC
- NGO and extractive industry staff in DRC require dedicated evacuation contingency plans
- East Africa operations — monitor al-Shabaab threat in Kenya; avoid northeastern border regions
- Morocco, South Africa, Rwanda (Kigali), and Ethiopia (Addis) manageable with standard protocols
- Fuel and supply chain disruptions from Iran crisis may affect in-country logistics planning
- Embed tactical medicine capability for any sub-Saharan deployment outside major urban centers

NOTABLE INCIDENTS / INDICATORS (Q1 2026)

DATE	LOCATION	INCIDENT	SIGNIFICANCE
Jan 2026	Ouahigouya, BF	JNIM attack on village — 40+ civilians killed	HIGH — Sahel expansion continues
Feb 2026	Goma, DRC	M23 forces advance to outskirts; 1M+ civilians displaced	HIGH — evacuation corridor required
Feb 2026	Lamu County, KE	Al-Shabaab ambush on security patrol — 8 killed	ELEV — heightened East Africa threat
Mar 2026	Tripoli, LY	Armed faction clash near airport road — temporary closure	HIGH — no access without armed escort

07 ASIA PACIFIC

THREAT LEVEL: **ELEVATED**

SITUATIONAL OVERVIEW

The Asia-Pacific region has moved to ELEVATED threat overall, driven by escalating China-Taiwan gray zone activity, South China Sea maritime incidents, and the broader geopolitical effects of US-China trade confrontation under the Trump administration. The Iran war's disruption of global energy and supply chains has amplified economic security risks throughout the INDOPACOM corridor. China-Taiwan tensions continue with PLA military exercises and increased gray zone provocations, though the Trump-Xi summit has reduced near-term kinetic escalation probability. The South China Sea saw a Chinese vessel ram a Philippine Coast Guard ship in February, underscoring ongoing territorial friction. Myanmar's civil war intensifies, with the junta losing territorial control to resistance forces in multiple regions. North Korea continues ballistic missile testing. US tariff escalation is generating economic instability and political backlash across Southeast and East Asia.

KEY THREAT DRIVERS

- China-Taiwan gray zone operations continuing with PLA air and naval intrusions
- South China Sea vessel rammings and confrontations between China and Philippine coast guard
- US tariffs and Chinese overcapacity creating trade-war-driven economic instability regionally
- Myanmar junta losing territorial control — civil war intensifying across multiple regions
- North Korea ICBM and SLBM testing — June 2025 twelve-day war context creating residual tension
- Iran crisis energy disruption cascading into Asian economies — political unrest risk rising

RECOMMENDED POSTURE

- Taiwan-based operations require updated contingency relocation plans and data protection protocols
- Myanmar — avoid all travel except Yangon with essential travel restrictions; extraction planning required
- Enhanced cybersecurity posture for all INDOPACOM operations — China APT activity at peak
- South Korea, Japan, Singapore, and Australia remain excellent security environments
- Philippines operations require monitoring of South China Sea corridor for maritime route disruption
- Energy price volatility creating social unrest indicators in fuel-import-dependent Asian states

NOTABLE INCIDENTS / INDICATORS (Q1 2026)

DATE	LOCATION	INCIDENT	SIGNIFICANCE
Feb 2026	S. China Sea	Chinese vessel rams Philippine Coast Guard ship near Scarborough	ELEV — maritime confrontation
Feb 2026	Taiwan Strait	PLA naval and air exercise with live-fire components	ELEV — contingency planning refresh
Mar 2026	Mandalay, Myanmar	Resistance forces take control of township; junta airstrikes	HIGH — avoid all Myanmar travel
Mar 2026	Seoul, KR	North Korean ICBM test falls in Japan EEZ — emergency session	MON — monitor for escalation

08 TRAVELER ADVISORY & RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

IMMEDIATE ACTIONS — CENTCOM AOR (CRITICAL)

- All personnel in the Gulf region (Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Jordan) should contact your security officer immediately
- Do not attempt to transit through any Gulf state airports until airspace status is confirmed — many routes remain disrupted
- If in Iran: shelter in place at fortified location and await embassy guidance — do not attempt land border crossings independently
- Maritime: zero transit through Strait of Hormuz or Red Sea until Hormuz is confirmed clear of Iranian enforcement
- Contact Aegis 24/7 operations line for real-time extraction support: personnel deployments available

PRE-TRAVEL BASELINE

- Subscribe to your government's traveler registration program (STEP for US nationals) — mandatory for all elevated AOR travel
- Obtain a region-specific intelligence briefing before departure — Iran crisis is generating cascading effects globally
- Ensure travel insurance covers medical evacuation and hostile environment scenarios — verify Iran conflict exclusions in policy
- Prepare an emergency communications plan including out-of-country contacts and a missed-check-in protocol
- Assemble a travel medicine kit appropriate to destination — trauma kit mandatory for CENTCOM and Africa deployments

IN-COUNTRY PROTOCOLS

- Maintain a low profile; avoid displaying corporate branding or wealth indicators
- Use vetted, professional ground transportation — avoid ride-share apps in elevated-threat areas
- Vary routines and routes to reduce predictability and targeting risk
- Identify nearest hospital, embassy, and emergency assembly point upon arrival
- Check in with designated contact on defined schedule; establish missed check-in protocol

DIGITAL & CYBER SECURITY — ELEVATED IN 2026

- Iranian APT and hacktivist groups are running active cyber operations against global energy, finance, and government targets
- Use encrypted communications (Signal) for sensitive discussions — verify voice calls via secondary channel due to AI deepfake threat
- Travel with clean devices where possible — remove sensitive corporate data before departure
- Avoid public Wi-Fi networks without VPN; apply emergency patch management before travel to CENTCOM-adjacent regions
- Cartel AI deepfake voice scams targeting executives in Mexico — verify all unusual requests via known contact numbers

MEDICAL READINESS

- Carry personal prescription medications in original packaging with documentation

- Trauma kit (tourniquet, hemostatic gauze, pressure bandage) is MANDATORY for CENTCOM, Africa, and Mexico deployments
- Consider Aegis Tactical Medicine Training for teams operating in elevated AORs — contact us to schedule
- Energy price spike and supply disruption from Iran crisis may affect medical supply availability in Gulf and African states

09 ABOUT AEGIS READINESS GROUP



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Readiness, Where It Matters.

Aegis Readiness Group is a veteran-led security consulting firm providing global security assessments, tactical medicine training, travel planning and intelligence, and executive protection services. Our team brings firsthand operational experience from complex, high-risk environments worldwide.

Our mission is to equip corporate travelers, executives, NGOs, and organizations with the intelligence, training, and operational support needed to operate confidently in environments where risk is a constant factor — not an afterthought.

■ Security Consulting	■ Tactical Medicine	✈ Travel Intelligence	■ Executive Protection
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